

As the final requirement of the WTC class Kim and I did earlier this year we need to complete two experience trips involving an overnight backpack with a peak and some cross country. The first was done with our friends and fellow students Bill & Katie on a trip to Cornell Peak near San Jacinto.

For the second trip Kim and I ended up on different outings. This past weekend she went with one of the WTC instructors to the San Geronio area and did Grinnell Peak, Lake Peak, and 10K Ridge as part of a Saturday and Sunday backpack. I joined the WTC group 2 leader on a somewhat more challenging trip up into the Sierras.

Due to permit issues we would be spending Sunday and Monday up in the mountains with Saturday night spent

Our campsite was to be Sam Mack Meadow, roughly 7.5 miles and 3,000 ft of gain from the trailhead above Big Pine (a minor town along the 395.) The plan had us hiking in at a non-strenuous pace Sunday starting early and then first thing Monday striking out for a local 3rd class (hands and feet required to climb) peak called Winchell 3 miles from camp. Afterwards we would pack out and I would get home in time to take the first flight out of Orange County Tuesday morning for a work trip.

Ron, Mark, and I left Orange County at 1 pm Sunday and headed north along the 395. We made a local ranger station in plenty of time to pick up our permit and we were informed that we didn't even need the rather heavy bear canisters we were lugging around with us. Ah well. In the name of simplicity we all used them anyway.

From Big Pine we drove 12 miles up a road to the trailhead and looked for a place to camp for the night.



As it would happen this is the same location we camped for the SMI snow class several months ago. It was getting dark as we arrived so other than scouting out the trailhead to check for parking we didn't do much more than pitch our tents and fall asleep.





Bright and early the next morning we packed up, crammed everything back into our backpacks, and went to the trailhead to meet up with the other leader on the trip, Virgil. Virgil and his girlfriend Gwen had come up two days before so they could take a more leisurely pace up to Sam Mack. Gwen was waiting back at camp and would theoretically meet us there later while Virgil had hoofed it down the 7.5 miles on his own the night before in order to meet us here.

Having his tent and most of his camping gear up on the mountain there was obviously somewhat of a discrepancy between our pack sizes.



My pack was a bit on the large size. I had a 2 person tent, a bear canister like the one above



As we started up the trail we had a good look at the bowl where the SMI snow class had been held. The snow field we had used to practice self arrest had of course melted.



Soon we were on to new territory (for me anyway) as we started our climb up the north fork area. path the glacier had receded.



Several miles in we came across one of the landmarks of the trip, the cabin of Lon Chaney, a famous actor from the silent film era. These days it is used as a camp and equipment storage location by the Wilderness Rangers. It's a very well constructed cabin and has a rather nice porch area facing Big Pine Creek.



We started to get views of some of the real mountains found back in this range. Above is Temple Craig, a rather imposing peak.





Next we started to pass the lakes. Named very simply First Lake, Second Lake, ect they were a striking turquoise color due to the glacial flour produced when the ice grinds against the rock. The color actually changed as we went further up and was quite striking.



After passing Third Lake you are basically to Sam Mack except for one last kick in the pants climb to get you up to the lip of the meadow at 11,000 ft.



Then, at long last, you arrive at Sam Mack Meadow itself. It's fairly small and split down the middle by a stream fed from lakes and glacier feed further up. Except for where we came up the meadow is surrounded by hillsides



The weather was warm, when the wind wasn't going it was easily t-shirt and shorts weather. We all took it easy for a bit and recovered for our climb while we waited for Gwen to join us.



Gwen, having been up in the meadow since the day before, was out on a solo hike to the nearby Palisade glacier and was due to return by 3 pm. When 4 pm rolled around with no sign of her Ron and Virgil set out to look for her while Mark and I waited back at camp. Maybe 30 minutes after they had

left another hiker came back down the same trail having visited the glacier himself. Unfortunately while he had seen Ron and Virgil on his way down he hadn't seen any sign of Gwen.

Fortunately at about 5:30 pm, just as Mark and I were seriously thinking we might be sending a runner for help to the trailhead if the search party came back empty handed Gwen herself came down the trail. She had apparently become turned around while exiting the moraine and had headed down the wrong ridge. She was partway down to Third Lake before recognizing her error and backtracking. She was needless to say rather tired from her all day trek.

Ron and Virgil returned a little after 6, moving a little slower than when they left but obviously happy to see Gwen was safe.

With everyone back in camp and the sun going down it was time for the Sierra Club tradition for all campouts, happy hour.





The more experienced folk among us (ie the leaders and Gwen) actually cooked while Mark and I stuck to sharing ready made items like salami slices and cheese spread. In addition in accordance with the Dave Black Rule of Backpacking I had carried a liter for red wine up the mountain with me and I put that out to share.



Soon we all had our fill and as always there was more food than we could comfortably eat. Without the ability to have a campfire most of us were happy enough to slip off to warm sleeping bags.

The next morning Ron didn't want to take the initial climb out of Sam Mack in the dark so we didn't leave camp until 6:30 am. With stripped down packs with helmets bouncing behind us we started up the rock face in the early morning twilight.



While somewhat daunting when viewed from a distance the route is fairly trivial once you get close. We made good time up the rock to the start of our true challenge, the moraine.



Moraine is a debris field left behind by a glacier and can best be summarized as a large pile of rocks of all sizes which have a nasty habit of shifting under your feet.

The trick to travel across the moraine, as described by Virgil, is to basically dance across the top of the rocks balancing on your feet and rarely using your hands. Of course you need to always be ready to shift your weight quickly to another rock should the one you're on start to roll.

We did have a minor mishap when one of Mark's water bottles came out of its holster and fell down between some rocks. At first we thought it was a goner but Virgil ended up saving the day by wriggling down between several rather large rocks.



It took us several hours to cross the relatively short distance to near the foot of Winchell. At that point it became apparently that at our current speed we would not make our summit window.



We ended up roughly 40 minutes from the true start of the climb to Winchell with 2 hours until our 11:30 am turnaround time. At that point the leaders made the call to return to camp without attempting to summit.





On the plus side from the point we reached we had impressive peaks in nearly 360 degrees around us. In addition we could see both the Palisade and Thunderbolt glaciers.

The return was actually much quicker now that our group was getting the hang of travel across the rocks. What had taken several hours to cross took roughly an hour to return across despite there being no less climbing.

We were back in camp by noon, well before the time Gwen was set to leave for the trailhead. We ate lunch, packed up, and started down the trail.

We kept a fair pace on the way down but of course by this time the packs were causing a fair amount of pain.

We made it out in daylight and bid Gwen and Virgil farewell at the trailhead as they were heading north for Mammoth to enjoy a few days hiking and seeing the sights.

Mark and I traded off driving on the way home and we reached Ron's house a little after 11 pm which put me home around midnight. Unfortunately a last minute work trip had me catching the first plane out of Santa Anna the next morning at 6:45 so it made for a very short night and early morning.